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WE ARE THE WORLD: Air Marshal T.S. Randhawa at NDA

NATIONAL DEFENCE ACADEMY, PUNE ARMS AND THOSE MEN

SILENT BATTLE As revenue minister, Morarji Desai opposed the gift of 6,400 acre to the academy. The army quietly got it approved by Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel. Commissioning it as chief minister six years later, Desai evidently got even. He expressed his disappointment that the armed forces did not commission their officers (the cadets generally head to their respective service academies from where they are commissioned).

A LITTLE DRAMA The first batch of cadets carved a plateau on the grounds using a borrowed bulldozer and built an open-air theatre. Years later, Shashi Kapoor got engaged to Jennifer Kendall here.

On the morning of the first passing out parade at the National Defence Academy (NDA) on June 5, 1955, Jawaharlal Nehru sat on a horse at the brink of its open-air theatre, not taking his gaze away from the sylvan surroundings of the new academy near the Khadakwasla lake. His thoughts are now inscribed in gold in the Sudan Building: 'Our great nation can advance only if we are united. Our army, our navy and our air force draw their men from all parts of the country and are a symbol of our unity and homogeneity. I wish all of us could imbibe that spirit.'

Hailed as the nursery of Indian military's leadership, the NDA was founded after the British received a rather generous gift of £1,00,000 from the Sudanese Government. It was

meant to create a war memorial for the Indian soldiers who had fallen in north Africa. Evidently, the money was better spent on the world's first tri-services training academy. The formal inauguration of the NDA took place on January 16, 1955, and so far it has churned out over 30,000 officers. Says NDA commandant Air Marshal T.S. Randhawa, "The academy has carved a niche for itself among military training academies in the world." Close to 600 cadets pass out each year, after a three-year regimen of physical and mental activity where the academy reshapes them into the military leaders of the armed forces, imbibing the spirit of Nehru's golden words.

by Sandeep Unnithan

"Unique in concept and exemplary in its performance, the NDA has left an indelible imprint on the history of the nation." AIR MARSHAL T.S. RANDHAWA, NDA COMMANDANT